Team 9 · Gracias Por Invitar (G.P.I)

CS 4390/5388 Software Project Management, The University of Texas at El Paso

To: [CEO's name], Chief Executive Officer

From: Team 9 project management team

Date: November 12, 2026

Subject: Crisis response and recommendation for the G.P.I pilot

1. Situation and Triage

What happened

Three weeks after we released the first version to pilot users in El Paso and Juárez, an update from Render broke our personalized feed. Render hosts our event site (gpi-j4aw.onrender.com), and our plan names no other outside provider, so we treat Render as the provider in this incident. Our project has no AI component, so we use the personalized feed (the "Feed ranked to categories" work package in our budget) because it is the most automated part of the system and decides on its own which events each user sees.

Since last night the feed has given every pilot user incorrect results. An event organizer in the pilot made decisions on that output for a full day, found the problem on their own, and emailed the CEO. We treat event organizers and venues as our highest-interest stakeholder because two of our charter's three success criteria depend on them; the charter's stakeholder table does not rate interest, so this is our assumption. Nobody on the team contacted them, and our Error Budget and Policy names only the team and the instructor as people to notify.

A review by pilot users found that Juárez users were affected much more than El Paso users. Naming Juárez is our assumption, based on the charter's constraint that Juárez event information "may be inconsistent or inaccurate." Waldo, our lead developer, built the feed and would normally apply Render's fix, but he resigned with ten business days' notice and the hiring freeze rules out a replacement. A post on a developer forum claims the update exposed customer data. Render says it has found no evidence of this and its investigation is still open, so the claim is unverified.

Immediate consequences

The feed stays offline until it passes a retest against the charter's success criteria, including the target that at least 80% of events are shown to users one week before the event. The repair and Render's emergency support fees use a third of our $6,443 contingency reserve. Half was already spent on the scope change the CEO approved earlier, so about $1,074 remains, which is about 13 hours of work at our budget rate of $82.18 an hour. Render's service credits arrive only 30 days after the incident closes. The schedule had no room for delays even before this: the charter allows 8 weeks, but our budget estimated 12.1.

Triage order

1. **Incorrect results (Emergency 1).** Every pilot user is still affected, and the stakeholder has already gone to the CEO. The other two emergencies depend on this one: the Juárez review needs the fixed feed and its retest data, and Waldo's ten days are planned around who applies the fix. It is also the emergency spending our reserve right now.
2. **Disproportionate impact on Juárez (Emergency 2).** It comes from the same fault, but the feed cannot return until the retest checks Juárez and El Paso results separately, which adds time to the retest. Juárez is one of the two cities the charter serves, and the organizer target counts organizers from both.
3. **Waldo's resignation (Emergency 3).** Nobody outside the team is harmed by it yet, and his notice gives us ten business days. We still decide on day one how he spends them, and any work we cannot reassign has to leave scope, which needs the CEO's approval.

Risk register check

Our portal has no finished risk register (the Sprint 4 change log still lists it as open), so we checked the two risk lists we have: the Step 9 risk table in the Project Budget and the three candidate risks in the Sprint 3 Competitor Field Study.

- Emergency 1 was missed, because neither list mentions Render or any other service the site runs on; the budget lists hosting only as a free-tier cost of $0, so we never treated the host as something the feed depends on.
- Emergency 2 was missed, because the closest entry, "Uneven El Paso-Juárez event data needs a cleanup and review pass (35 hrs)," treats Juárez data as a cleanup cost and never asks whether the system could give Juárez users worse results.
- Emergency 3 was missed, because the staffing plan counts developers only by role (2.73 FTE-months), so nothing showed that one developer held most of what the team knows about the feed.

2. Decision Log

#	Time	Emergency	Decision	Options rejected	Reasoning	Owner	Reversible?
D1	3:45 pm	1	Take the personalized feed offline and post a site notice; the calendar and date list stay up.	Leave the feed on; take the whole site down.	Every pilot user gets wrong results, and SLO 1's budget is spent, so our policy says to halt event listing.	Emmanuel (Incident Leader); done by Samuel and Christian	Yes, after the retest passes.
D2	4:10 pm	1	Reply to the organizer, copying the CEO: confirm the wrong output and that the feed is offline, and treat the data exposure claim as unverified.	Wait for the retest; announce a possible breach.	Nobody told the organizer. Render reports no evidence of exposure, and its investigation is open.	Jazmin (Communicator), approved by Emmanuel	No
D3	4:25 pm	1 & 3	A developer other than Waldo and the QA engineer apply Render's fix and retest against the charter's 80% criterion. Spend about $2,148 (⅓ of the $6,443 reserve), leaving about $1,074.	Waldo applies the fix; wait for Render's root-cause report.	An independent retest catches more errors, and Waldo's time is needed for knowledge transfer (D5).	Emmanuel	Yes, until the fees are paid.
D4	4:35 pm	2	The feed returns only after Juárez and El Paso each pass the retest separately.	One combined retest; restore El Paso first.	A combined score could hide the Juárez gap. The charter serves both cities.	Emmanuel (incident owner)	Yes
D5	4:45 pm	3	Waldo's ten days go to knowledge transfer, starting with documenting how the feed ranks events (Section 6).	Waldo leads the fix; keep him as a contractor.	Only he knows the ranking logic, and a contractor would bypass the hiring freeze.	Emmanuel	Yes, day by day
D6	4:55 pm	1 & 2	**Revises D3:** the retest covers each city separately (D4), adding about 6 hours; the QA engineer leads the Juárez pass.	Keep D3's single retest.	D4 changed what the retest must show.	Emmanuel	Yes, until the retest begins

3. Governance Response

This is the first version of our governance response, written on November 12, 2026, after the incident. Before this morning, G.P.I had no AI governance plan: no risk classification of the personalized feed, no bias monitoring, no one responsible for handling this kind of incident, and no documentation of how the feed reaches its results. Since our project has no AI model, this response applies to the personalized feed, the most automated part of the system (Section 1).

3.1 Incident Owner

Emmanuel Saenz, Project Manager, is the owner of the bias incident. As stated in the project charter, he is responsible for planning and team scheduling, and he reports to the sponsor. The Error Budget and Policy names him Incident Leader as well, giving him the authority to keep the feed offline, direct the site fixers (Samuel Alderete and Christian Lopez-Matulessy), call for separate Juárez and El Paso retest results, and escalate to the CEO any decision that requires spending contingency or changing the current scope.

Emmanuel is a good candidate to be the incident owner because he owns SLO 1 (event data quality), so the weekly audit will measure the gap between the cities, which is already one of his responsibilities. Keeping one

owner for Emergencies 1 and 2 will let us keep a single chain of command for a single fault. To limit his load, messages to Juárez pilot users go through Jazmin Huerta, the Communicator named in the Error Budget and Policy.

3.2 Risk Classification

We used the NIST AI Risk Management Framework. The feed sits at the Map function: we never recorded who it serves, which groups it could harm, or what it depends on. The charter noted that Juárez and El Paso data "may be inconsistent or inaccurate," but only as a data constraint, not as a risk that Juárez users could get worse results. We did not use the EU AI Act because an event feed would fall in its "minimal-risk tier", which would require no actions.

Function	Action now	Owner	Time
Govern	Name Incident owner (3.1); feed releases need his sign-off	Emmanuel	1 h
Map	Document the feed's inputs (organizer listings, the eight interest categories), its Render dependency and the groups it serves	Waldo, his successor	6 h
Measure	Retest each city separately; start the monitoring in 3.3	Site Fixers	6 h
Manage	Feed stays offline until both cities pass; review when the incident closes	Emmanuel	2 h

Estimated total: 15 hours ($1,233 at $82.18), more than the ≈ $1,074 left in contingency. At 50 team-hours a week, this adds about two working days to a 12.1-week schedule. The Map work must happen within Waldo's ten days.

3.3 Bias Monitoring Plan

We will have one test account per city, set to the same interests, recording their top 20 feed items each day. Each item will be scored with our SLO 1 "Good to go" checklist, the metric being the share of correct items per city. Oscar Vargas, owner of our SLI document, will escalate to Emmanuel the same day if either city falls below 95% (more than 1 wrong item in 20) or if one city scores 2 or more items lower than the other. These checks will run daily during the pilot and after every Render update or deploy, logged in the Thursday audit sheet.

3.4 Transparency Response

The evidence says	What our records can't tell us	What we would have needed
The feed ranks events by the interests users pick from eight categories. A Render update caused wrong results for all pilot users, and Juárez users were hit harder. The feed will stay offline until each city passes a retest.	Why Juárez was hit harder, how many Juárez users saw wrong results, or for how long. Whether results were already uneven before (our audit and monitor never ran). Whether any data was exposed.	A written description of the ranking logic. A log of feed output by user and city. A data-quality baseline per city. A dependency record naming Render, the version our site runs on, and its update history. Waldo's notes on how the feed ranks events, which do not exist today.

4. Delivery and Reliability Impact

Which SLO was breached

SLO	Target and budget	What happened	Breached?
SLO 1: event data quality	95% of 20 sampled listings real and current each week. Budget: 1 inaccurate listing a week.	Since the update, every pilot user has seen incorrect results, and one organizer acted on them for a full day.	Yes. Two wrong listings in 20 already put a week at 90%. We cannot say by how much, because the first Thursday audit has not run.
SLO 2: website availability	99% of each 336-hour sprint. Budget: about 3 hours 20 minutes of downtime.	The site kept responding. We took the feed offline ourselves.	Not as defined, because SLO 2 counts the site answering, not the feed working. Counted as downtime, the feed's outage would spend the whole sprint budget on its first day offline.

Error budget and required action

SLO 1's budget for this week is spent, so our policy applies: halt event listing, correct every incorrect listing, and double the audit sample to 40 the following week, which for the feed means keeping it offline (D1). The 40-listing audit will also be our first, at about 1.5 to 2 hours instead of the 45 to 60 minutes the SLI document gives for 20. Our escalation table makes this Severity 2: fixing starts within 12 hours, and the instructor hears in the weekly update.

Dashboard metrics

None changed that we can report. We have no dashboard, and the two logs that would feed one, the Thursday audit and the uptime monitor, are still open items in the Sprint 4 change log. From the incident itself, not from a measurement: data quality fell, availability as SLO 2 measures it held, and the feed went from on to off.

What would have caught it first

Even running, both measurements could have missed this: SLO 1 samples the listings themselves, not what the feed shows each user, and SLO 2 only asks whether the site answers. To catch the problem before users did, the dashboard needed the check Section 3.3 now sets up: each city's test-account results side by side, checked every day and after every Render update or deploy, with Render's updates on the same timeline. A weekly audit can find a one-day failure a week after it starts; the organizer lost a full day.

5. Updated Risk Register Entries

Risk	Chance	Impact	EMV	Owner	Early Warning Signal	Trigger Response	Last Response Validation
Render update breaks the feed	10%	$2,148	$215	Samuel	Render announces an update or deploy, or a daily test-account item is wrong	Samuel runs the 3.3 check within 1 hour of any Render update. If a city falls below 19 of 20, Emmanuel takes the feed offline.	Never
Juárez users get worse feed results than El Paso users	20%	$2,876	$575	Oscar	Juárez test account scores 2 or more items below El Paso, or either city is below 19 of 20	Oscar escalates to Emmanuel the same day. Emmanuel keeps the feed off for that city and calls the separate retest	Never
Waldo's undocumented ranking logic leaves with him	30%	$6,057	$1,817	Emmanuel	By end of day 3, the ranking write-up is not drafted, or the receiving developer cannot explain it.	Emmanuel puts Waldo on documentation only and takes the scope cut in 6 to the CEO for approval	Never

6. Personnel Transition Plan

Knowledge Transfer

Waldo designed the feed, wrote most of its code, and documented almost nothing (Section 3.4). We have not yet interviewed him, so this list comes from D5 and Section 3.4 and must be confirmed with him on day 1. Four things must exist in writing before he leaves: (1) how the feed ranks events for the eight interest categories; (2) how the feed is deployed on Render, including settings and the steps to take it offline and back on; (3) how Juárez and El Paso listings reach the feed and whether the two cities are handled differently; (4) known bugs and shortcuts. The receiving developer must be able to explain each item before Waldo leaves.

Ten-Business-Day Handoff

Day	Waldo's work	Knowledge handed over	Receives it
1	Two-hour walkthrough of the feed code and the Render deploy so the fix and retest (D3) can start.	Code layout; how to deploy and take the feed offline	Developer, QA engineer, Samuel, Christian
1 to 3	Writes the ranking description: inputs, the eight categories, how events are ordered. This is also the Map work in 3.2.	Ranking logic	Developer
4 to 5	Writes the Render record (version, settings, update history) and the list of known bugs and shortcuts.	Render dependency; known issues	Samuel, Christian, developer
6 to 7	Shows how Juárez and El Paso data enters the feed; helps design the per-city retest (D4, D6).	City data flow	QA engineer, developer
8 to 9	Watches the developer make a small change alone, fixes gaps in the notes, records a walkthrough.	Working practice	Developer
10	Sign-off: developer explains the ranking back; Waldo hands over his access.	Final check	Emmanuel signs off

Reassignment of Responsibilities

Ranking logic and feed code go to the developer who applied the fix (D3), in the development team; the retest and per-city checks to the QA engineer; the Render account and the offline switch to Samuel and Christian; daily test-account results and escalation to Oscar; sign-off and overall ownership to Emmanuel.

Cognitive Load and Skills Gaps

Waldo's work moves to the developer and QA engineer, who are already busy with the fix, the separate retests for each city, and part of the 15 hours of governance work. Adding his work on top is too much for them, and our $1,074 contingency cannot pay for extra help. Because our portal has no topology diagram, we assume the development team normally just hands finished work to the Site Fixers (Samuel and Christian). For the next ten days they should work closely together instead, with a short daily check-in, and go back to the old arrangement once Emmanuel signs off. The skills gap is new: nobody except Waldo knows how the feed ranks events. It also makes our Render knowledge worse, because we never tracked Render as something we depend on.

Scope Adjustment

We recommend removing Search by name or keyword from scope. Search does not support the charter's success criteria, and it uses the same developers and QA engineer who must now absorb Waldo's work. Removing it frees 73.7 hours ($6,057 at $82.18), which covers the roughly $159 by which the 15 governance hours ($1,233) exceed the $1,074 left in contingency, with room to spare for the ranking work. Emmanuel brings the request to the CEO, who approves it, as she approved the earlier scope change. If Section 7 recommends continuing as planned, this cut is the fallback.

7. CEO Briefing

Part A: Five Key Messages

1. The feed gave inaccurate data, and we didn't tell the people affected. Since yesterday, pilot users were shown incorrect and inaccurate event listings. We took the feed offline at 7:30. Per our Error Budget and Policy, we are only required to notify the team and the instructor, which is why we still haven't reached out to the users.
2. Juárez users were hit harder, and the feed will stay offline until both cities pass. Users reported more inaccurate results in Juárez than in El Paso. The feed will remain offline until both cities pass the test, including the stated 80% of events shown one week ahead in the charter.
3. A developer forum claims Render's update exposed customer data. Render reached back and stated they have no evidence of this yet. This is something we are still looking into, so in the meantime, the data-exposure claim remains unconfirmed.
4. The repair plus Render's emergency fees cost about $2,148, leaving us with $1,074 of our $6,443 reserve, which is about 13 hours of work. The governance work in Section 3 needs 15 hours, $1,233. Waldo, who built the feed, leaves in ten business days, and the hiring freeze means we can't replace him. His remaining time will be going into documenting how the feed works, because nobody else knows the ranking logic.
5. Our recommendation is cutting the scope, and we need an approval ASAP. Details can be found in Part C.

Part B: What We Will Not Say

1. We will keep the data exposure claim unconfirmed. Render's investigation is still open and there's no evidence either way. Saying it happened without proof would cause an alarm. However, we cannot say it did not happen either.
2. We will not blame Render or Waldo. Render's update triggered this, but our risk lists never named Render as a dependency for the feed. Waldo cannot be blamed either because our staffing plan counted developers by role and never asked who actually held the knowledge.
3. We will not give a return date for the feed yet. The return date depends on a retest that hasn't run yet. Thursday's audit hasn't happened, so any percentage we offered would just be a guess.

Part C: Executive Recommendation

Our recommendation is cutting the scope by freezing the personalized feed at its repaired version for the rest of the pilot. Once the feed passes the retests for both cities, we bring it back. We will not be building any new feed features until the pilot ends.

The reason we are choosing this option is because we want to keep going as planned where we commit to feed work that nobody will be able to do once Waldo leaves. It also commits money we don't have since $1,233 of

governance work is more than the $1,074 left in the reserve, and the schedule was already at 12.1 weeks against the charter's 8. Pausing everything would stop the retest and Waldo's knowledge documentation. However, cutting the scope keeps the fix, the retest, and the documentation, and drops the work we can no longer staff. What we need from you is the approval to change the scope for us to keep the feed at its repaired version, keep the feed offline until both cities pass the retest, and agree to Emmanuel signing off on every feed release from now on. The only thing that would change this recommendation is if Render confirms that customer data was exposed, at which point we would recommend pausing the project and notifying all affected users before doing anything else.

Signatures

Emmanuel Saenz, Project Manager

Samuel Alderete, Portal Lead

Jazmin Huerta, Market Research Lead

Oscar Vargas, Business Strategy Lead

Christian Lopez-Matulessy, Research Documentation Lead

Appendix A: Response Log

When (Nov 12, 2026)	Who	How	What
3:00–3:40 pm	Emmanuel, Samuel, Christian, Jazmin, Oscar	Teams Call	Triage of the three emergencies. Recorded by Emmanuel
3:40–4:00 pm	Samuel, Christian	Teams Call	Took feed offline and posted the site notice. Christian kept the running triage log
4:00–4:15 pm	Jazmin, Emmanuel	Teams Call	Replied to the organizer confirming the incorrect results and the offline feed
4:20–5:00 pm	Emmanuel, Samuel, Christian, Oscar, Jazmin	Teams Call	Drafted Sections 1-4
5:20–6:00 pm	Oscar	Teams Call	Wrote sections 5 and 6
5:00–6:00 pm	Emmanuel	Teams Call	Wrote Section 7 and this appendix
8:00–8:15 pm	Emmanuel, Samuel, Jazmin, Christian, Oscar	Teams Call	Final review of the document, included electronic signatures

Appendix B

The use of Claude AI was leveraged as an editing assistant for creating the template for this document. Additionally, it was used by some team members to correct grammar for certain sections and ensure the document is formatted properly.

Claude AI was also used to help review some of our earlier documents to help us keep our information accurate.